

100 Days of Linux - Day 035

Title: Combining Files with paste

Today's Goal

Learn how to combine multiple files side by side using the **paste** command.

Why This Matters

Data engineers often merge related datasets, reports, and lists. The **paste** command helps combine files line by line.

Command of the Day: paste

Syntax: paste file1 file2

Common Options:

paste names.txt departments.txt

paste -d ',' file1 file2 (use comma as delimiter)

paste -d '|' file1 file2

Explanation: Combines corresponding lines from two or more files into a single output.

Beginner Lesson

Imagine you have one file containing employee names and another containing departments. Instead of editing them manually, **paste** combines matching lines automatically.

Practice Questions

1. Create names.txt and departments.txt with five matching lines. Combine them using paste.
2. Combine names.txt and departments.txt using a comma as the delimiter.
3. Create ids.txt and combine ids.txt, names.txt, and departments.txt into one output.
4. Save the combined output into employees.csv and display it using cat.
5. Display your current working directory after completing today's tasks.

Hints

Ensure each file has the same number of lines for the cleanest output.

Mini Challenge

Create product_ids.txt, products.txt, and prices.txt. Merge them into products.csv using commas as delimiters, then count the lines with wc -l.

Common Mistakes

Using files with different numbers of lines, which can produce uneven output.

Did You Know?

The paste command joins files horizontally, while cat displays files vertically.

Pro Tip

Use paste to quickly build simple CSV files from separate columns.

Answer Key (Instructor Only)

Q1: paste names.txt departments.txt

Q2: paste -d ',' names.txt departments.txt

Q3: paste ids.txt names.txt departments.txt

Q4: paste -d ',' ids.txt names.txt departments.txt > employees.csv
&& cat employees.csv

Q5: pwd

Homework

Create three text files and practice merging them with different delimiters such as commas, tabs, and pipes.

Next Day Preview

Tomorrow you'll learn the tr command to translate, replace, and delete characters from text.